TikTok, YouTube and other social media apps use your behaviour to recommend content that it deems interesting to you through personalised algorithms, in order to keep you online as long as possible, to sell more advertising space and to collect more and more of your data. Have you ever googled a product and found it advertised to you *everywhere* you go online after that? It's because your data is being bought and sold across the internet for a range of purposes. In 2017, *The Economist* magazine reported that data has now become more valuable than oil.

artificial intelligence (AI)
computer systems able to perform tasks normally requiring human intelligence, such as visual perception, speech recognition, decision-making, and translation between languages

More troubling is the relationship between machine learning or **artificial intelligence (AI)** to analyse your data, watch your behaviour and, eventually, predict it for you. Theorist, scholar and author Shoshana Zuboff named this new industry 'Surveillance Capitalism' after the long-hidden business model of major companies harvesting our online behaviour for profit. Machine learning, which is essentially sophisticated algorithms, analyses your behaviour and learns from it, creating better and more accurate predictions the more data you put into the system. There isn't a human deciding what you watch on YouTube, but a complex mathematical equation.

CASE STUDY 6.18

Data privacy

Every human has the right to privacy, yet we have quietly signed all this away when signing up to countless apps and services with long and tedious terms and conditions that we never read. In 2020, a Russian-based 'Age My Face' app had a brief moment of internet popularity when people could take selfies and see what they would look like in 30 or 40 years. What few realised at the time was the terms and conditions allowed the owners of the app to have access to their entire photo library 'in perpetuity', which is a legal term for 'forever'. How and why the app stored this data was never made clear. Yet, for many users of the app, they no longer owned exclusive rights to their own faces. What's worse, they had handed it over for free.



FIGURE 6.37 What kind of privacy should we expect of our data?

How bad could it be? Especially if you have nothing to hide? While it may not affect you personally, how your data is used could affect others. In Zuboff's 2019 book *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, she points to a trend in data collection that goes far beyond the media and into almost every aspect of our lives. Your behaviour on social media, or any internet-connected device, generates data that can be bought, sold and manipulated to meet the ends of anyone with the money and motivation to use it.

In 2016, a data company called Cambridge Analytica used the Facebook data of millions of Americans to determine who could be persuaded to vote for Donald Trump. Using bots, false and misleading posts, they inundated the feeds of these 'persuadables' in an effort to engineer the US Presidential election in favour of Donald Trump. Democracy itself was challenged by the data millions of users have created.

Yet, in more simple terms, if you own a Google Home or Alexa device,[11] your private home conversations could be recorded while your wi-fi-enabled robotic vacuum cleaner creates a schematic of your house and its contents. If you have ever thought about tracing your ancestry through Ancestry.com, you may have your own DNA data hacked and sold to the highest bidder.[12]

ISBN 978-1-009-36510-9 Hoban et al
© Cambridge University Press & Assessment 2023
Photocopying is restricted under law and this material must not be transferred to another party.